

Review Article

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Abstract: Sweet Conspiracy: A Review of Artan R. Hoxha's *Sugarland*

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Sugarland: The Rise and Fall of the Albanian Sugar Complex, by Artan R. Hoxha. New York: Berghahn Books, 2023. 256 pp. Illustrations, notes, bibliography, index. \$120.00 (cloth), ISBN 978-1-78920-756-6; \$34.95 (paper), ISBN 978-1-78920-757-3.

Artan Hoxha's story of Maliq—swamp, sugar combine, and then a town—invites a revisionist thesis worthy of our house methodology: communist Albania did not merely imitate the capitalist sugar complex; it reverse-engineered it as a tool of rule.

In this reading, sugar becomes a low-cost political technology. Cheap to grow or import, easy to warehouse, infinitely mixable into rations, pastries, and hooch, sucrose let the state centralize scarcity and then theatrically relieve it—one saccharine queue at a time. If opium was famously the religion of the masses, sugar was the more practical liturgy: a daily, edible promise that the Party still had the means to sweeten the lives of those it suppressed. The regime's longevity owed less to ideology than to glycemic governance.

The plot begins, fittingly, in mud—both literal and figurative. Hoxha wades through a swamp of images, now casting Maliq as internal colonization, now as frontier myth, then as the conveyor by which central power reaches the periphery. From our conspiratorial vantage, these are not competing frames but footprints of a single maneuver: seize land, regulate flows (water, beets, labor), and retrain appetites. The Soviet-gifted combine of the late 1940s was more than a factory; it was a shrine to socialist developmentalism, a machine-priesthood that manufactured peat and beet into calories and consent.

Sugar offered a triple dividend. Economically, it promised a substitute for volatile grain imports, while preferential trade—Cuba, COMECON—often kept sugar comparatively cheap and stable. Politically, it enabled monopoly—a single choke point across import, production, and distribution. Socially, it standardized taste around a manageable addiction.

Hoxha's narrative also shows that every government would, and in effect did, make the same sugar bet. Across regimes—from monarchy to Italian patronage to Stalinist autarky—the instrument keeps returning: central projects that reorder land and diets at scale. This is intentional convergence, not coincidence: the governing class repeatedly selects sugar because it is cheaper than proteins and vegetables, easier to ship than fresh produce, and more pliable than grain in the politics of queues. Post-1990s privatization and the combine's collapse do not break the pattern; they merely pivot it. The state shifts from producer to importer, preserving a choke point over a sweet commodity central to the national diet—only now the state is captured by new elites, the oligarchs (Ferro & Co.), who pull the same lever for new rents and a new fast-food diet.

Here the book's strongest materials—drainage schemes, forced labor, collectivization, the expert/peasant tussle—read as evidence of a “sweet discipline.” The agronomist calibrates sucrose; the planner calibrates desire; the peasant ferments nicely underneath. Calories arrive wrapped in Party messaging (*Karamele Zana*): modernization, self-reliance, progress.

One can quarrel with the author's scatter of metaphors (frontier, shrine, machine, factory) and the lack of a single analytical spine, but even the metaphor pile-up unwittingly maps our thesis: sugar was the master metaphor because it was the master lever. And lever meant leverage over regions, rations, and reputations.

Did it work? The book is thin on time series for consumption, imports, and dietary substitution—precisely the gaps a serious conspiracy loves to exploit. But we can nevertheless gain the insight that the regime maintained the theater of provision even when agriculture underperformed, swapping legumes and dairy for saccharides and cushioning decline and discontent with candy and alcohol. Not prosperity—pacification by pastry and raki.

And after 1991, the costumes change and the script remain. The combine's ruins are leased to a politically connected seafood magnate; Sugar Town becomes Fish City – another concessionary miracle of modernity. The sugar monopoly migrates to the docks of Brazil and Durrës.

In this reframe, Sugarland is less a case study of modernization gone awry than a manual of affective statecraft. Sugar's very cheapness is the feature: it lets authorities perform abundance at a discount, smoothing discontent with reliable spikes of pleasure. Now it can be cocaine or crack, meth or methadone, but the principle holds: addictive commodities are the opiates of the masses because they are also the instruments of rule. The state that can sweeten lives can also discipline them.

Despite its theoretical clutter and wayward comparisons half a world away, Hoxha provides the scenes and props to stage this sugary argument. Where it lists frontier, we read accretion of control. Where it itemizes instruments—reclamation, collectivization, regionalization—we see dosage forms of self- and collective-discipline. Where it laments the post-1990s destruction of capital stock and the dissolution of cooperatives and the common good, we see the great pivot from central planning of domestic produce to ports of imported goods and dependence subsidized by the transport of drugs through the same routes. And where it ends on the industry's demise, our conspiracy file concludes that where industries die, addictions adapt. In Maliq, the saccharine regime now smells fishy—just like the captured state.